THE LOCI SYSTEM

One drawback to the linking system, as you'll have been bright and attentive enough to realize, is that if you get stuck on one word, the whole chain breaks down. Surely, for the blossoming new student of all things retentive, this is simply not good enough. Allow me, then, to introduce to you with embarrassingly inappropriate enthusiasm a mnemonic that involves no such danger: the 'loci system'. At its best, this mnemonic contains a delectable sorcery and a saucy Lecter-quality that make it irresistible. Fans of the Thomas Harris novel *Hannibal* will be aware of Lecter's memory palace: this is the loci system taken to its delightful extreme.

The loci system, synonymous with the Greek art of memory, has its origins in a tale about a banquet that took place around 500 BC. Simonides of Ceos (I won't ask you to remember all of these names, but I do hope that you'll pay attention) was a poet, hired by the noble Scopas to offer a poem of praise to the latter at a huge party he was throwing. Simonides recited the poem as planned, but Scopas was jealous of the opening fawning remarks to the gods, which preceded those to himself, and paid the poet only half of his agreed fee as retaliation for this divided doxology. Simonides was then approached by a messenger and asked to step outside. Within those vital minutes of his being without, the angry gods destroyed the banquet hall, Scopas and the entire party. Bodies were so terribly mutilated that they could not be recognized. The ancient Greeks were not great with dental records, and there was no way of identifying the deceased. However, our poet hero knew the loci system and was able to identify each and every dinner guest as he had memorized his or her location around the banquet tables.

This story comes from Cicero's *De oratore*, and Simonides' methods were first explained in 85 BC by an unknown Roman author in a

fascinating textbook on rhetoric called *Ad Herennium*. In the Middle Ages, interest in the system was given new life by St Thomas Aquinas, who strongly promoted its use as part of his rules for living a pious and ethical life, and it also became widely used by the Jesuits. Later, Matteo Ricci, a sixteenth-century Italian Jesuit priest who worked in China, wrote much about it in his *A Treatise on Mnemonics*. But it was the colourful character Giordano Bruno who really did his best to spread the word around that time.

Bruno was a Jesuit monk, an astronomer, an astrologer and a spy who was excommunicated and travelled around telling all with ears to hear about the systems. For him, mnemonics were magical devices, tied in with astrology and Hermetic occultism. He developed a system of imaginary memory wheels, showing the orbit of the heavens, and attached to them symbols for the arts, language and science. It was a kind of mnemonic orrery, and he believed that through this system the order of the cosmos could be understood. This level of esoterica soon had him branded a heretic, and he was burned at the stake in 1600. Meanwhile, the loci system was taught in many English schools until 1584, when Puritan reformers declared it unholy for encouraging bizarre and irreverent images. This beautiful and life-enhancing ability therefore lost its place among the proudest achievements of human consciousness because some religious zealots didn't like the level of imagination it provoked.

In its simplest form, the loci mnemonic works by attaching images to places along a familiar real-life route you know well. The images represent items to be remembered, and are placed in fixed locations you know you will always encounter on that route. For example, let us imagine that the route you choose is the path along your street to your home, and then into the house and each of the rooms in a natural and fixed sequence. If you decide on a starting point now, some way down your street, and begin to

mentally walk towards your house, notice a few familiar points along the way. For example, there might be a shop or two you always pass, a zebra crossing you always use, or a post-box that stands out. These are your 'loci', or locations. Then, as you approach the door to your building, make the porch or entrance-way another location. If there is a hallway to an apartment door, you might find further loci to use: a lift, a letter-rack, and then the door to the apartment itself.

Now you need to mentally walk through your house. You can do this for real, but there is an advantage in simply doing it from memory, namely that you are less likely to overlook in the future those things that will occur to you now. Find a fixed object in the hallway to use as the next location. Then move into the first room, and choose something obvious there. If you are in your sitting room, you might want to use the television, your fish-tank, your DVD collection or your sofa. Then move into another room and choose another location. Continue this until all the rooms of the house have been used, and you know where your finishing point is.

Now re-cap that route in your mind and check that you anticipate and pay attention to each location. This will serve as your fixed route, and it is important that it is very familiar.

Now let's use it for memorizing. Let's imagine you have a list of things to remember for the day. Here is a suitably bland generic one:

1 : Buy stamps.
2 : Take suit to dry-cleaner.
3 : Tell X at work to call Y (think of actual people).
4 : Get mobile phone fixed.
5 : Feed the parrot.
6 : Phone Dave.
7 : Record *Trick of the Mind*.
8 : Buy rubbish on eBay.
9 : Double-check video-recorder.

Now begin your loci route. Your first task is to buy stamps, so mentally place an obvious 'stamps' image in front of your first location. You are not 'linking' here so much as simply placing a strong visual representation of each task where you can see it. If that first location is a shop, perhaps imagine a huge stamp stuck across the window. It must be something clearly visible. Then move on to your second location, and vividly attach to it the second item on the list, such as a sparkling suit or coat (use an item from your wardrobe) radiating dazzling light, to represent the dry-cleaning errand. Take a second or two to lock each of these into your mind. Continue with the list above, or substitute your own tasks, linking each to the next location on the journey. If 'phone Dave' links with, for example, the refrigerator in the kitchen, you might wish to walk in and see him stood by the open fridge, on your phone, drinking your milk. Obviously dispense with these random examples and use your own as they occur to you.

When you are done, you now have in your mind a familiar journey you can take, in your imagination, at any time you wish to review your tasks. As you embark upon it, take a look at each location along the way, and your tasks will present themselves to you. If any are hazy, take a moment to change the picture to something more memorable. Remember, the images must be *vivid* and *clear* (which means you need to take a moment to represent them as large, bright pictures to yourself), and *unusual* enough to stand out. You'll find there really is no effort required in seeing each item to remember, as long as you clearly placed them there.

The joy of this system is that if you do forget any one item on the list, you can continue your journey to the next one without trouble. As already noted, the linking system does not have that advantage. If you are making a speech, this method is perhaps preferable, as the process keeps moving you forward to the next point. With the

linking version, you may have to backtrack to check what your previous point started out as, in order to know what comes next.

Memory Palaces

Once you have mastered this principle, you might like to take it to higher levels, where it really can become a thing of beauty. As it stands, the system as I have just shown it to you does have certain limitations. Firstly, you are limited by the number of loci on your journey, and cannot remember more than one list at a time. If you tried to start another list simultaneously at that shop with the giant stamp on the window, you'd get terribly confused.

So the first step is to expand the number of loci in, say, each room of your home. The kitchen offers not only a refrigerator, but also a cutlery drawer, an oven and any number of places where images can be attached. All that's important is that your room does not become cluttered, so that the images are clear and distinct. That is why it is a good idea, wherever possible, to have the action take place *inside* something: for example, Dave sat *in* the fridge allows you to have something happening *next* to the fridge as well, without Dave and that something else getting in the way of each other. It used to be considered important to place great distance between loci, though it does seem that this is not the case. However, *distinction* between loci does matter.

Once you do use multiple loci for each room, bear in mind you need always to go through them in a fixed order. Contrary to the Greek recommendation, I use a system of moving clockwise, so I always start with something on my immediate left and work my way around the room.

Another way of expanding your loci system is to allow for the use of permanently retained information. In other words, rather than just using it for information such as tasks and speeches which you can

comfortably allow to fade from memory (the loci themselves remain fixed, but the objects placed in them will fade when not used), you can also designate other rooms, spaces or buildings to hold useful information you prefer to keep hold of. So once you are very familiar with your loci system at home, you may wish to expand the setting to form a more complex interconnection of buildings, which you can imagine as a sprawling palace. You can begin by adding an extra door to the imaginary representation of your house and have it open up into another familiar environment. In that new building you keep the information stored, and you wander around it occasionally to re-awaken and review what you have there.

When I first began using these techniques, I used my old school to expand my memory places. However, it quickly occurred to me that places which are dim in the memory, or which have associations that are both good and bad, are less than ideal: both serve to distance one from the picture and make it more of an effort to imagine oneself inside the place, looking out of one's own eyes, as it were. I re-read Thomas Harris's chapter, where we see that Lecter is able to lose himself inside a labyrinth of palace rooms and grand chambers, and I realized the pleasure of using far grander environments to store useful data.

This is more in keeping with the original use of the system set out by the author of *Ad Herennium*. Students were encouraged to find and use suitable places from life for the 'artificial memory', rather than relying on their homes. The loci inside each building were expected to be of moderate size, clearly lit (but not too bright), and placed about thirty feet from each other. Anyone unsure about finding sufficiently good loci is told that he should have no problem, 'for thought can embrace any region whatsoever and in it and at will construct the setting of some locus'. This suggestion of using fictitious places to complement real-life ones

does allow for the construction of some wonderful imaginary dwellings, extending in all directions and with countless different rooms for different purposes.

Whether you use fictitious or real places to add to your expanding palace, this improvement relies on you being very familiar with them. Personally I would not recommend the use of invented spaces, as you must first concentrate on remembering *them*, which seems pointless. If I find myself in a suitable and aesthetically appropriate place that I wish to add to my own palace, I make a point of memorizing it, perhaps even photographing it for good measure, and then returning to it a few times to really fix it in the memory. If you do choose to employ this system, I can recommend, as does the Roman author, that you spend your time memorizing the real space when it is as free from crowds as possible. In this way I have 'taken' floors from museums (ignoring all but the exhibits which tend to stick most in the mind), as well as London parks, parts of my school and university, favourite theatres I have visited or performed in, stately residences and the homes of friends. Many of these I link together with grand stairwells and marble hallways, inspired by the chapter in *Hannibal*.

If, for example, you wished to remember a list of the works of Shakespeare in the order that they were written, you might ideally take a trip to the Globe, or the Swan in Stratford, and walk a fixed route through it a few times, choosing enough loci that stick so firmly in the mind that they are no effort to remember. You might begin with the entrance to the theatre, then the foyer, the box-office, the bar and so on, placing at each point a clear representation of what you wish to remember. However, they must be firmly imprinted on the memory, as it is important that you never struggle to recall the loci themselves, no more than you would struggle to remember the rooms in your own house. Once you are very happy that you can

take that journey in your mind and recall everything, you can then walk back through and place an image for each play in each locus.

I mention this example because once, during a theatre run in glittering London's busy West End, I used the interior of the Cambridge Theatre to commit to memory the Bard's plays in order. This theatre forms part of my own memory palace, always holding that information. The process took about ten minutes and has stayed well in my mind. By taking you through the sequence as it still remains in my head, you will see how a loci journey might work. I have mixed the strict loci method, which normally consists of fixed, isolated images, and involved characters which move and interact with me to aid the mnemonics. I've also used the peg system, which I will explain later, to include some numbers.

Coming in through the stage door, I see two rather grand gentlemen in the little office to my right (*Two Gentlemen of Verona*). They offer me a mug (*'mug', in the peg system that follows, is a code for 39, so this tells me there are thirty-nine plays*). I say hello, and move towards the lift, which necessitates climbing a few stairs ahead of me. In doing so, I find a schoolboy coming the other way with homework that has been much corrected by a teacher in red pen, and we find ourselves unable to pass each other: we amusingly step to the same side, then again, and again, laughing at our repeated mistake (*Comedy of Errors*). As I open the lift door, out steps the imposing figure of *King John*, splendid in his regal attire but bearing the face of John Major, so that I am never confused as to which king it is. I step in, and the lift begins to rise. On the first floor I am joined by Prince Harry with bees buzzing around his head (*Henry VI Part One: the 'bees' represent 6 from the peg system, which will be explained later*). He is followed by Anthony Hopkins in character as *Titus Andronicus*, but Titus does not make it into the lift. I pass floors two and three (*Parts 2 and 3*) with Harry, and then the lift

stops and he and his buzzing irritants step out. As they leave, I hear Harry's wife shouting gracelessly at him (*The Taming of the Shrew*).

I get out of the lift on the top floor, where my dressing room was situated. As I leave the cabin, I feel the unpleasant sensation of stepping into a sticky brown stool (*Richard III*), left by the company dog, and I see next to it a disappointed note from the cleaner saying that all the affection she puts into keeping the place clean has been wasted (*Love's Labour's Lost*). I walk to my dressing room, but first see that the side of the corridor has been made into a balcony overlooking a painted scene (*Romeo and Juliet*). Walking closer to it, I see that the balcony is decorated with carvings of fairies, and in the middle is a man with a donkey's head (*Midsummer Night's Dream*).

I cross now to my dressing room, and see that there is not one but two good-luck cards pinned to the door from my good friend Richard (*Richard II*). Before I can open the door, it opens for me, and the writer/comedian Stephen Merchant comes out and walks past me (*Merchant of Venice*). We greet each other, and I enter. Inside, there is immediately to my left a statue of Harry again, but this time shown with a whore (*Henry IV Part One: the 'whore' relates to 4 in the peg system*). Moving always left to right, next to it is the fridge, and I open it to see a group of tiny women laughing about their husbands (*Merry Wives of Windsor*). In the further corner, by the entrance to the make-up and changing area, I see a second statue of Harry and the whore (*Part 2*), and then I look on my sofa. Sat there is a nervous old lady in a terrible state about nothing in particular (*Much Ado About Nothing*), and next to her on the little table is a smaller statue of Harry, but this time with a beehive for his bees (*Henry V: again, the peg system will give us 5 from this image*). Now I step into the make-up area, to see that the cleaner has taped a note to the mirror, telling me proudly that she has left the room *As You Like It*, and I am grateful. When I look to my right in this

room, I see that the white shower curtain has a blood-stained rip in it, and I am reminded of *Julius Caesar*.

I leave my dressing room and decide to take the stairs down to the stage. As I approach them, I see that there is a child's wind-up toy spinning at the top, and I am reminded that the century has now turned. We now continue with the plays written from 1600 onwards. Stepping down onto the first step, I see that the first few have a layer of cress growing on them (*Troilus and Cressida*). Halfway down the stairs, in the corner as I turn, there is another statue, this time of an unhappy pig, *Hamlet*, and etched into the wall just past him I see that an equally unhappy actor from a previous production has scratched marks on the wall like a prisoner to count the nights of his performances: I see twelve (*Twelfth Night*). However, at the end of the marks he has carved a 'smiley' into the plaster, and I guess that he was happy enough to be done at the end (*All's Well That Ends Well*). As I come to the bottom of the stairs, I see a racist slogan scrawled on the wall (*Othello*) and I use the side of a ruler that hangs at the base of the stairs (*Measure for Measure*) to try to scrape it off.

I enter through the door into the backstage area, and see that the stage is set for a Greek play. I see the Acropolis and a friend from school stood before it – Timothy (*Timon of Athens*). I walk across the stage and step down into the auditorium. Sat in the front row is an old man with two rather fawning daughters at his side (*King Lear*), and a little further back a bloodstained king (*Macbeth*). My feet strike what I think at first is a pipe across the aisle, but I see it is a periscope from a submarine (*Pericles*). I pick it up, and a small piece of coral (*Coriolanus*) falls off it, presumably snagged during some nautical voyage. At the door at the back of the stalls I find Anthony (*Antony and Cleopatra*), one of the executive producers of my TV programmes, who would sometimes come to see the show. I walk through into the lobby and find Michael, my manager,

loudly playing the cymbals (*Cymbeline*). I pass him and look out on to the street: it is covered in thick snow (*The Winter's Tale*). Needing the fresh air, and continuing on my journey, I decide to brave the weather and step out anyway, but as I do I am knocked over by a sudden and terrible *Tempest*, and it is only through the ministrations of two helpful twins (*Two Noble Kinsmen*) that I am brought back to my feet. Ahead of me, walking down Monmouth Street towards Seven Dials, I see the great old magician Cardini, who, drunk as ever, seems rather lost (*Cardenio, the play lost to us in written form*). Finally, I turn and look back at the theatre. In place of the large picture of me that had graced the façade of the building, I see a huge painting of Henry VIII, in familiar garb.

Such is my journey through the theatre in which I performed.

Your home can link to a place like this through an extra doorway or a favourite garden, which also stores a wealth of information you have wished to keep. That way you can begin to enjoy the pleasure of wandering around in these private locales during occasional quiet moments, unlocking their secrets for your own edification. The auto-hypnotic quality of such excursions really makes the whole process quite delightful, and it is important to re-awaken these from time to time to make sure that items don't fade. After a while, each journey happens quickly and easily, and you are propelled forward quite automatically.

One final thought. The Greeks suggested that you add a marker every five loci on your journey. For example, a hand with the fingers splayed as the fifth loci would remind you that this was number five on the list. That way if you needed to recall, for example, the twelfth item on your list, you could walk straight to the 'ten' marker and then continue on two more. It's a rather neat addition, and echoes the 'turning of the century' marker I placed at the top of the Cambridge stairs.